

be compelled by it. He does, indeed, show with a formidable array of evidence that the canonical recension of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh. *might well be* much later than the First Esdras recension, but he fails to show that it *is* in fact later. His assumption (*Proceedings Soc. Bib. Arch.*, May, 1901, p. 151), that any Greek translation which closely follows the text of our present Hebrew Bible must be derived from Aquila, Symmachus, or Theodotion, will hardly be accepted by those who have carefully studied the Greek Old Testament. He assumes, in like manner, that the canonical Greek version of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh. is the work of Theodotion—as Grotius, Whiston, and Pohlmann had conjectured before him—but without being able to bring forward any shred of evidence in favor of this opinion, beyond the fact that Theodotion's version of Daniel has found a place in our Greek Bible. The one prime necessity—if the current beliefs as to the Ezra books are to be superseded—is a well-grounded and plausible theory of the origin and mutual relations of the two recensions now existing. Such a theory has never been formulated,³ and Howorth has failed to provide one. His main conclusions, touching these matters, are the following: (1) First Esdras gives us the original form of this history; that is, (a) the *order* in our apocryphon (Ezr. 4: 7-24 following Ezr. 1: 11, and Neh. 7: 73-8: 12 following Ezr. 10: 44) is the primary and correct one; and (b) the Story of the Three Youths formed a part of the history as it was compiled by its author. (Howorth makes no attempt to prove that our Greek text of the story is a translation from the Semitic, though this proof—which has never been supplied—is essential to his theory.) (2) Origen, or perhaps "his editors," made our First Esdras by cutting a piece out of the middle of the "Septuagint"⁴ version of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh., and then editing and correcting it to some extent. (3) Our canonical Ezra-Nehemiah is the result of a thoroughgoing and arbitrary re-arrangement of the text, undertaken by the Jewish rabbis, who (a) knew nothing of Darius (II) Nothus, and (b) wished to identify Zerubbabel

³ The theory which is set forth in the following pages was presented in full at the meeting of the American Oriental Society at Andover, Mass., in April, 1896, but was not printed.

⁴ I suppose that Howorth means by "the Septuagint" that Greek translation of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh. which was the first to gain wide currency. I do not understand him to imply the belief that all—or even most—of the books of the Old Testament were translated at the same time, or by the same persons, or in any official or uniform way. Would it not be better, in the interest of clearness and accuracy, to cease altogether from using the term "Septuagint" in scientific treatise?